

NINELIVES

The saying 'like a cat with nine lives' is based on the old belief that it is hard to kill or get rid of a cat; that cats seem to survive many life threatening situations. The saying is not a reference to cats at all; it is a simile. You might hear someone say of a champion tennis player, "He struggled in every game, but as you can see, he's got 'as many lives as a cat'."

- *Why is it said of the champion tennis player that he has 'as many lives as a cat'?*

SALT BLOCKS

The common table salt that we use on our food is sourced in two ways. Salt is found in the Earth's crust and in sea water. We must have a certain level of it in our diet to maintain good health. Not all foods naturally contain adequate amounts of this mineral, so we need to add it during the preparation of meals or just before eating. Similarly, some farmers put blocks of salt out in their fields or holding sheds.

- *Why do you think some farmers put out salt blocks?*

IMMOBILISED

It took us nearly three hours to travel from home to the beautiful but isolated beach the Scotts had told us about. It was a scorching day. We had several swims, a picnic lunch and a long leisurely walk to the headland. On the way back my three-year-old brother wanted to jump the waves. Dad walked out until the water was almost up to his knees and holding Henry's hands lifted him over breaking waves. He was squealing with delight until a big wave broke. Henry got a mouthful of water.

When we got back to the car to head home Dad discovered the car's remote locking device and engine immobiliser didn't work. Water had got into it and he couldn't start the engine. What's more, there was no mobile phone coverage. It was midnight when Mr Scott returned with our spare remote.

- How do you think the remote device had got water in it?
- Did the Scotts go with them to the beach? Why do you say that?

HORSESHOES

The sides and underside of a horse's hooves consist of a form of hardened skin - similar to human nails. Like nails they keep growing, but can be chipped and worn down by use.

Horses in the wild do not have protection for their hooves. Although they can move at speed, especially when running for their lives, they generally move at a slow pace. If there is any damage to the hooves it can be serious. Lamé horses can become easy prey.

When people began keeping horses, they used them to carry heavy loads as well as riding on their backs. The riders quite often made them gallop. As most people who had a horse wanted it to be useful for as long as possible, they realised that they needed to find a way to look after their hooves.

Horsemen in Asia a thousand years ago made socks from animal skins or wove them from plants to put on their horses' hooves.

In the second century AD Roman riders put 'hipposandals'* on their horses. These were made from leather and metal that fitted over the horses' hooves, and were tied on with leather straps.

In northern Europe, the ground was often soft and wet. This was not only a problem for horses to walk on, it also softened their hooves. Various ways of fixing these problems were tried. By the sixth century metal shoes were being nailed onto hooves. By the year 1000 AD horse shoes were used throughout Europe. The early shoes were made from bronze, but later ones were made from iron and were heavier.

In England, coins as well as horseshoes were made of iron; the shoes were sometimes more valuable. In the 12th Century, horseshoes were accepted in the place of money to pay taxes. The collected shoes were then used on soldiers' horses.

Today, most horseshoes are made of steel, although some are made of aluminium, titanium, rubber or plastic.

*hippo is the Latin word for horse. Latin is the language spoken by the ancient Romans.

- How can a wild horse become 'easy prey'?
- Why did people begin to shoe their horses?
- Why do you think the Romans called their horseshoes hipposandals?
- Do you think using metal shoes for soft, wet ground was successful? Why do you say that?

REACTION QUESTION

- Do you think it is cruel to nail metal shoes onto horses' hooves? Why do you say that?